audacious that one would not believe them but for contemporary accounts of them. Using the volcanic outcrops of the Deccan Traps, the Marathas repeatedly outwitted the larger Mughal armies and remained a constant thorn in Aurangzeb's side. One of my favourite tales is about how the Marathas captured Sinhagadh by using a trained monitor lizard named Yeshwanti to scale the walls. The guerrillas tied a rope around the lizard, which climbed up a rock-face that was so steep that it had been left unguarded. A boy then climbed up the rope and secured it for the rest. The fort of Sinhagad is just outside Pune and can be easily visited. You will see cadets from the nearby military training school climbing up the hill with their heavy packs.

Another group that broke out in open revolt were the Bundelas. Their leader Raja Chhatrasaal used the low hills of the Vindhya range to wage a campaign against the Mughals. There is a colourful tale that links the Bundelas and the Marathas. Raja Chhatrasaal had a very beautiful dancer named Mastani in his court (some claim she may have been his daughter by a concubine). When the Marathas rescued the Bundela chief from a tight spot, Chhatrasaal thanked the Maratha commander Baji Rao by gifting him Mastani. Baji Rao would rise to become the Peshwa (Prime Minister) of the Marathas and Mastani would become his favourite. Although Mastani is usually left out of history books, she was a significant figure in her times and is said to have ridden with Baji Rao on his many campaigns. On the highway between Orchha and Khajuraho, there is a small but picturesque palace built on a lake by Chhatrasaal for Mastani during her younger days. Not many people know about it and visitors are likely to have it all to themselves. The surrounding hills are heavily fortified, a reminder of the turbulent times in which Mastani lived.

Nonetheless, it was not at the hands of the Marathas or the Bundelas that the Mughals suffered their first decisive defeat. This happened in the middle of the Brahmaputra in faraway Assam at the hands of the Ahom general Lachit Borphukan. The Ahoms came to India as refugees in the early thirteenth century. They were distantly related to the Thais from what is now the Burma–China border and were probably no more than a few